opinion that the performance of companies is better compared with that of its peers. This approach would make comparisons rational as it factors the influence of the external environment that may constrain or benefit similar businesses, such as the financial meltdown of 2007–08. He underlined its significance in a letter he sent to the Tata companies a day after Mistry was replaced.

But Mistry reacted fiercely to his removal. He took ‘every opportunity to denounce his dismissal with venom’, commented the *Financial Times*. His reaction to the ouster was swift, all-out and unbridled. Many were surprised to the extent to which he dug feverishly to malign his predecessor. The criticisms ranged from alleged corporate misgovernance and the poor performance of companies to even questioning Ratan’s personal integrity. But it was an inadvisable move.

Many Tata veterans believe that Mistry had hoped the Tata Sons board would oppose his removal. That may have clouded his judgement, rendering him oblivious to the fact that he was going up against someone of Ratan’s stature. Further, the era of CEOs being blindly supported by boards had changed. Boards had become more loyal to companies. As an article in *The New Yorker* said, ‘In the old days, boards were often loyal to the C.E.O. … Today, they’re more loyal to the company … Some C.E.O.s have a very lofty opinion of themselves, and when they’re told they have to go they’re almost always shocked.’ Many Tata veterans opine after his replacement, that an admittedly ‘shocked’ Mistry had boxed himself into a delusional corner.

Not many could believe that the same Mistry who in the foreword in *Tata Review, Special Edition, January 2013, Ratan N. Tata, A Tribute*, had written—‘In 2006, I joined the board of Tata Sons and started to interact with Mr Tata more closely. What impressed me immediately was the breadth and depth of his knowledge, about how well informed he was and his willingness to hear you out’—was now using anything and everything that he had against the man he had so admired and praised.

The day after his replacement, Mistry made an acerbic attack on Ratan in a letter marked ‘Confidential’, which was sent to sixteen Tata Sons board members and Tata Trusts trustees. The *Financial Times* termed it ‘searing’. In another article, it published the full text of the letter with the subheading: ‘Sacked chairman pours scorn on predecessor in email to conglomerate’s board’.